of India outside. It was gloriously young. It was all jeans and sneakers and spiffy hairstyles and swagger... Inside the iron bars, it is the old who practise servility. The young rule... The wasteland of iron bars was also the zone of magical thinking... the iron sang all the time." Never once does he mention the word 'jail' or 'prison' because that becomes subjective and judgemental.

Tejpal's imagination is faceted—fertile and furious, conjuring up stunning scenes, characters, insights around the man-made universe of crime and punishment—all at a breathless pace—and yet in all this frenzy, he repeatedly strikes the beautifully slow and languorous note of love, in the preternatural romance of Asambhav and Aranya. Without declaring it once, the book makes it clear that the pure kernel inside of so much crime is made of urgent love and desire, gone wrong or made to go wrong.

The book pulls off the supreme sleight of great art—it triggers empathy for every manner of beast, even the most wretched. In telling stories of the underclass, the wronged, the wronging, Tejpal doesn't write of them, he becomes them. Because for six long months, he was them, only a skin away. The feat of his polyphony is staggering. He inhabits endless skins as if he were a djinn—cops, murderers, lovers, judges, lawyers—tracking their inner and outer lives with equal insight. The book is peppered with aphorisms, wisdom juiced down to glittering nuggets, each destined eventually to an independent life outside of the book, yet embedded perfectly inside of it. If you begin marking each, you are guaranteed a pencil-mangled copy.

Kafka wrote, as his axiom for literature, "I think we ought to read only the kind of books that wound or stab us. If the book we're reading doesn't wake us up with a blow to the head, what are we reading for? A book must be the axe for the frozen sea within us." *The Line of Mercy* is that book. For those who get into it, it is perhaps the greatest novel of Indian literature. And perhaps even one of the greatest of our age.

Mercy is a thrilling song of despair—it sings the underclass in all their stark realities, in the burden of their injustice and deprivations. Tejpal demonstrates you need no ketchup when the chutney is flowing. He has created a magnificent real-life opera (all the way to a truly operatic finale) that most of the *gauche caviar* writers cannot hope to approach in their Covid-asepticised laptops on their sterile study tables. Five seasons of an OTT series will flourish on these characters—finding wing on slushy streets where Asambhav and Aranya metaphorically poke each other with their umbrellas, accidentally exchanged, to be caressed later in their rival homes in a very Bollywood pathos.

With intellectual irreverence and bleeding heart, *Mercy* guides literature back into an alliance with the wronged. It brutally reminds the cosy lot—the sippers of toast and tea, of gin and tonic—that they suffer only charmed griefs.

This reviewer's enthusiasm may seem excessive to those who haven't read *The Line of Mercy* yet. But true art always sleeps in the promise of posterity. It sings of Chaucer and Cervantes, Dante and Dostoevsky, of Sophocles and Shakespeare, of Plato and Proust. With or without any alliteration, it will also sing of the un-rusting iron in the sentences of the double-barrelled Tarun and Tejpal. ■

–Aman Nath

(The writer is an author, architectural restorer and chairman of Neemrana Hotels)

BOOK MARKING

***Aman Nath** picks lines from* The Line of Mercy *that impacted him most*

"There is a natural chasm between the literary and the military which only a great war can bridge"

"There was no way for him to know that literature is not a weapon for the conquest of the world. It is mainly a bomb to explode the self and in the atoms of the fragments to sift for the meaning of first things"

"How did men who had a surplus to eat get to make laws for men who had so little to eat?"

"Indians don't need facts. They need fictions. And the most compelling fictions are always those that tell of the venalities of the good."

"Long relationships layer and deepen by the sharing of vulnerabilities. Marriages thrive on failings. Couples fit into each other in their softness. Two bodies of metal can hardly lie together in intimacy."

"Religion understands men better than science. Science tells us we are an exquisite cocktail of chemicals. Religion knows men are nothing but hope and fear. And both are intensely private things."

"It is a melancholic irony that life is short and yet most people struggle to fill it"

"Fear—more than age—turns muscles into spaghetti"

"Men need to dramatise sorrow in order to deal with it."

"More than the world the truly great artists need to dazzle themselves."